

Is Nisan always the first month of the year?

“Of course it is!”, we might all say. But, you may be surprised to learn that the answer is actually: **not always**. Keep reading to learn how. First, let’s have a review of the Hebrew months.

Month names				
#	Pre-exilic (before Babylonian exile)	Babylonian (Akkadian)	Post-exilic (after Babylonian exile)	Gregorian (modern)
1	Abib (Exo 12:2, 13:4)	Nīsannu	Nisan / Nysan (Est 3:7)	March – April (Passover)
2	Zif (1Ki 6:1)	Ayyāru (Airu)	Iyar / Iyyar / Airu	April - May
3	third month* (Exo 19:1)	Sīmannu	Sivan / Siwan (Est 8:9)	May – June (Shavuot)
4	fourth month* (2Ki 25:3)	Du’ūzu (Duzu)	Tammuz / Tamuz	June - July
5	fifth month* (Num 33:38)	Abu	Ab / Av / Menachem Av*	July – August (Tisha B’Av)
6	sixth month* (1Ch 27:9)	Ulūlu	Elul / Ellul (Neh 6:15*, Hag 1:15*)	August - September
7	Ethanim (1Ki 8:2)	Tašrītu	Tisri / Tishrei / Tishri	September – October (Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur)
8	Bul (1Ki 6:38)	Arakhsamna (Arasamnu)	Marchesvan / Cheshvan / Mar-Cheshvan	October - November
9	ninth month* (1Ch 27:12)	Kislimu (Kislinu)	Chisleu / Kislev / Chislev (Zec 7:1)	November – December (Hanukkah)
10	tenth month* (Gen 8:5)	Ṭebētu	Tebeth / Tevet / Tebet (Est 2:16)	December - January
11	eleventh month* (Deu 1:3)	Šabāṭu	Sebat / Shevat / Sh’vat / Shebat (Zec 1:7)	January – February (Tu BiShvat)
12	twelfth month* (2Ki 25:27)	Addaru	Adar / Adar I (Est 3:7)	February – March (Purim)
13			Leap Month Adar II / Adar Sheni / Adar Bet	March (7 times every 19 years)

* = Known only by their number (there is no record of their names inside or outside the Bible).

* = Does not prove the month name.

* = Historically, the destruction of both temples occurred on the 9th day of this month (Tisha B’Av).

Now that we've reviewed the Hebrew months, let's have a look at the book of **Nehemiah**. After reading chapter one and two it should be clear that the events of chapter one **must have** occurred **before** the events of chapter two. Chapters one and two are written in chronological order.

Nehemiah 1:1

The words of Nehemiah the son of Hachaliah. And it came to pass **in the month Chisleu**, in the **twentieth year**, as I was in Shushan the palace,

Nehemiah 2:1

And it came to pass **in the month Nisan**, in the **twentieth year** of Artaxerxes the king, that wine was before him: and I took up the wine, and gave it unto the king. Now I had not been beforetime sad in his presence.

Now, if we look back at our calendar we might notice something interesting: The month Chisleu is the **ninth month**. Then, the following "year" the events of chapter two occur in the **first month** Nisan. But, they are both called **the 20th year**. How can they both be in the 20th year if chapter one started in the 9th month? What we're seeing here is a Biblical fact that answers the first question: is Nisan always the first month of the year? Not always. To those of us who are used to using a single calendar throughout the year this can seem confusing at first but it's really quite simple: the Hebrews didn't use a single calendar throughout the year, they had two:

1. The religious / feasts / Levitical calendar
 - The year begins with Nisan and ends with Adar.
 - This "holy" calendar ensures that God's commands are kept.
2. The civil / fiscal calendar
 - The year begins with Tishrei (7th) and ends with Elul (6th).
 - This "common" calendar aligned with the harvest seasons and simplified the administration, economics, and logistics of taxes, tithes, tributes, labor contracts, the releasing of debts and servants, etc.

ADDITIONAL INFO

There is also archeological evidence that suggests that they had another third "calendar" as evidenced by "The Gezer Calendar" discovered in 1908 (which dates to the reign of Solomon, ~10th century B.C.). For the purposes of this study we will focus on the two prominent calendars used throughout daily Hebrew life.

So, now that we have found evidence of the two calendar systems that the Hebrews used, the next logical question is why would they do that? At first it seems like that would make things more complicated but for them it actually made things far more simple. You have to think of it from an economics point of view. The primary reason why it would be more complicated for us to live by two different calendars and yet it was more simple for them to is because we no longer live in a **primarily agrarian** society.

A modern parallel can help us to understand the economics of their situation better. When are taxes due in the USA? By the end of the first quarter of **the new year** and as early as **the first month of the year**. Notice how our fiscal year lines up with our calendar year? The Hebrew government was no different than any other – the administration gets more complicated (expensive) when the fiscal year doesn't line up with the calendar year. Money has to be made **before** it can be used for anything else (taxes or otherwise).

The primary difference for the Hebrews is that their fiscal year began **at the end of harvest** in the season we call fall. Remember they needed time to both harvest and sell their crops. It's simply impossible to pay your taxes for the "year" if you haven't sold your harvest yet. And thus their civil/fiscal calendar began exactly where you would expect it to: well after the end of the harvest season which is the 7th month Tishrei (September-October).

Simply put, **Nehemiah 1:1 & 2:1** uses the civil/fiscal calendar and not the religious calendar.

Calendars elsewhere in the Bible

Is there evidence and proof of this dual calendar system elsewhere in the Bible? There most definitely is.

First, if you weren't already aware, the entire old testament uses a counting system called "inclusive counting". Simply put, **any part of a year** is counted as **a year**. Thus, a duration of 7 years and 6 months would be called "8 years" in inclusive counting. In modern times we almost exclusively use "exclusive counting" and so when we see an inclusive count we often refer to it as "rounding up". For more details and proof of this see the article "The reckoning of days" at <https://cheerful-wmcdannell.wordpress.com/2026/04/16/the-reckoning-of-days/>.

The civil calendar: Solomon's temple (1 Kings 6)

1 Kings 6:1

And it came to pass in the four hundred and eightieth year after the children of Israel were come out of the land of Egypt, **in the fourth year of Solomon's reign** over Israel, **in the month Zif**, which is **the second month**, that he began to build the house of the LORD.

1 Kings 6:37

In the fourth year was the foundation of the house of the LORD laid, **in the month Zif**:

1 Kings 6:38

And **in the eleventh year**, **in the month Bul**, which is **the eighth month**, was the house finished throughout all the parts thereof, and according to all the fashion of it. So was he seven years in building it.

If we use the religious Nisan-Nisan calendar to calculate the time elapsed from the beginning of the building of the temple to the end it looks like the following:

Year 11 – Year 4 = 7 years
Month 2 → Month 8 = 6 months

In inclusive counting, this duration would be called "8 years". But, **1 Kings 6:38f** very clearly states "So was he **seven years** in building it."

Let's redo the calculation using the Tishrei-Tishrei civil calendar:

Month 2 → Month 7 = 5 months
Year 4 → Year 10 = 6 years
Month 7 → Month 8 (11th year) = 1 month

Total = 6 years, 6 months (78 months)

In inclusive counting 6 years and 6 months would be called "7 months" which perfectly aligns with **1Ki 6:38**. Thus, the building of Solomons temple uses the civil (Tishrei-Tishrei) calendar and not the religious calendar (Nisan-Nisan).

The religious calendar: Haggai & Zechariah

Being contemporaries both Haggai and Zechariah had their ministries during the reign of king Darius of Persia. Unlike Artaxerxes, of which there are two kings of Persia named, there was only one Darius king of Persia.

A simple search for the phrase “second year of Darius” reveals the following:

Haggai 1:1

In the second year of Darius the king, in the sixth month, in the first day of the month, came the word of the LORD by Haggai the prophet unto Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, governor of Judah, and to Joshua the son of Josedech, the high priest, saying,

Haggai 1:15

In the four and twentieth day of the sixth month, in the second year of Darius the king.

Haggai 2:10

In the four and twentieth day of the ninth month, in the second year of Darius, came the word of the LORD by Haggai the prophet, saying,

Zechariah 1:1

In the eighth month, in the second year of Darius, came the word of the LORD unto Zechariah, the son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo the prophet, saying,

Zechariah 1:7

Upon the four and twentieth day of the eleventh month, which is the month Sebat, in the second year of Darius, came the word of the LORD unto Zechariah, the son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo the prophet, saying,

All of these events occurring in the 6th, 8th, 9th, and 11th month and still being called the same, **second year** make it clear that both Haggai & Zechariah are using the Nisan-Nisan religious (spring-to-spring Persian) calendar. Otherwise, we would expect to see that any month after the 6th month would be in the third (next) year.

And so, if anyone ever asks us “is Nisan the first month of the year?” we can confidently say: not always!